Unarchived
THE FAMILIES BEHIND THE FORTUNES

ARCHIVE FILE
FAMILY RECORDS

The Family Legacy *Checklist*

What history's richest families got wrong, and simple steps to protect your own.

Edith Rockefeller McCormick was born into the greatest fortune in America. She did not lose it in a single day. It leaked away over years: through grief, through illness, through people who stood close to the money, and through one enormous bet that left almost nothing protected.

Most of us will never hold a Rockefeller fortune. But every family has something worth protecting: a home, savings, the people who depend on us, and the stories we hope to pass on. This checklist turns the hard lessons of famous families into a few calm, practical steps.

HOW TO USE THIS FILE

1. Work through one section at a time. There's no need to finish in a day.
2. Tick each box once it's done, or note what's missing.
3. Bring the completed list to an estate attorney or financial adviser. It will save you time and fees.
4. Revisit it once a year, and after any major life change.

"She had everything. What she needed most was someone who could tell her no."
FROM FILE No. 001 · THE ROCKEFELLER DAUGHTER

DOCUMENT I The Will

When there is no clear will, the law and sometimes the courts decide who gets what.

- [ ] **I have a written, signed will** that meets the legal requirements where I live. Witness rules vary by state and country.
- [ ] **I've named an executor I trust**, plus a backup in case they can't serve.
- [ ] **I've named a guardian** for any minor children or dependents.
- [ ] **My executor knows where the original is kept** and how to reach my attorney.
- [ ] **I've reviewed it since my last big life event**: a marriage, divorce, birth, death, move or major purchase.

DOCUMENT II Beneficiaries

Many accounts pass outside your will, so the beneficiary form is what counts.

- [ ] **I've checked the beneficiaries** on retirement accounts, life insurance and annuities.
- [ ] **I've named backup (contingent) beneficiaries** on each.
- [ ] **I've asked my bank** about payable-on-death or transfer-on-death options.
- [ ] **No ex-spouse or late relative** is still listed by mistake.

DOCUMENT III If I Can't Speak

Illness can take away your voice. Decide now who speaks for you.

- [ ] **Durable power of attorney** for my finances.
- [ ] **Healthcare proxy and advance directive** (a living will).
- [ ] **Medical-records permission** (in the US, a HIPAA authorization) so loved ones can get information.
- [ ] I chose people who will protect **my** interests, **not simply who is closest to the money.**

DOCUMENT IV Trusts: Ask About Them

The great fortunes used trusts for a reason. Many ordinary families can too.

- [ ] **I've asked an attorney** whether a revocable living trust makes sense for me, for example to avoid probate, add privacy or plan for illness.
- [ ] **Special-needs planning** is in place if a loved one relies on benefits.
- [ ] **I've considered protections** for an heir who may struggle with money.

DOCUMENT V Protect the Money

Edith's fortune didn't vanish. It was spent, lent and bet.

- [ ] **No single investment, venture or person** controls most of what I have.
- [ ] **I get a second opinion** before any large financial decision.
- [ ] **I check the credentials** of anyone advising me on money. In the US, FINRA BrokerCheck is free.
- [ ] **I know the warning signs** of financial exploitation of older adults: sudden pressure, secrecy, new "friends" and unusual withdrawals.

FROM THE ARCHIVE

In 1922, Edith went to court to protect her 17-year-old daughter from a man she believed was after the family money. A few years later, the people around Edith herself would face the very same question.

DOCUMENT VI The Family File

The most painful estates are the ones nobody can find.

- [ ] **One master list** of accounts, policies, property and debts.
- [ ] **Digital accounts** noted, with a secure way for loved ones to access them (such as a password manager's emergency access).
- [ ] **Where the originals are**: the will, deeds, titles and any safe deposit box.

DOCUMENT VII The Conversation

Silence is the thread that runs through almost every file we open.

- [ ] **My family knows my plans** and who to call.
- [ ] **I've written a letter of wishes**: values, memories, and who should have the heirlooms.
- [ ] **I've recorded the family stories** before they're lost.

FAMILY RECORD · KEEP WITH YOUR WILL

Who to Call

Fill this in by hand and keep it somewhere your family can find it.

ROLE	NAME	PHONE / EMAIL
Executor		
Backup executor		
Power of attorney (finances)		
Healthcare proxy		
Estate attorney		
Financial adviser / accountant		
Where my documents are kept		

ANNUAL REVIEW · TICK THE YEAR

- [ ] 20___ - [ ] 20___ - [ ] 20___ - [ ] 20___ - [ ] 20___

Important: This checklist is general educational information, not legal, tax or financial advice. Laws differ by state and country, and every family's situation is different. Please speak with a qualified estate attorney or financial professional before making decisions. Historical details are drawn from published sources, including Ron Chernow's *Titan*.